

SOCIAL PROTECTION IN BELGIUM

ESSPROS DATA 2023



Federal Public Service
Social Security

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After the exceptionally high inflation year of 2022, 2023 started with continued significant price increases, mainly due to the ongoing effects of the energy crisis. Over the course of the year, inflationary pressure eased as energy prices fell, but pressure on the socio-economic system and, consequently, on social protection remained.

In this context, this edition of the ESSPROS brochure provides an overview of trends in social protection expenditure and receipts in Belgium and Europe. The first part examines ESSPROS statistical data for Belgium for the year 2023, along with preliminary estimates for 2024, compiled within the framework of Eurostat's 'Early Estimates'.

Social protection expenditure in Belgium rose significantly in 2023. This increase is partly attributable to the automatic indexation mechanism for social benefits in Belgium, which compensates for high inflation. On the other hand, the trends in the number of benefit recipients continued: while the number of people entitled to benefits such as temporary unemployment and the crisis bridging right for self-employed persons continued to decline, resulting in a decrease for the "Unem-

ployment" function, the number of pensioners continued to grow under the influence of the ageing of our population, with effects on expenditure on old age, sickness and disability. But these are not, of course, the only factors explaining these developments.

These developments also had an impact on receipts, which also continued to rise. In 2023, the importance of government contributions increased slightly, mainly due to government measures to limit the impact of the energy crisis and inflation. However, contributions from employers and protected persons continue to contribute the largest share of social protection funding.

According to preliminary estimates for 2024, social benefit expenditure is expected to increase further by 7.28%. This increase is partly attributable to factors influencing the individual level of social benefits, but also to policy measures taken, supplemented by demographic developments such as ageing. In addition to higher expenditure on pensions and healthcare, there is also a notable increase in disability benefits and social allowances within the child benefit system.



The second part of this brochure broadens the perspective by comparing Belgian data for 2022 with that of other EU member states. Various factors that continued to fuel social challenges in our country also did so in other EU countries. The analysis highlights the common challenges faced by member states in light of the energy crisis and provides an overview of trends reported in the aforementioned 'Early Estimates.'

This publication aims to be an informative and concise source on social protection in Belgium and Europe in the light of the developments and challenges facing social protection systems. The data we collect from many partners in order to meet our international reporting obligations also allows us to make international comparisons, but above all, we hope that this brochure will provide insight into the complex dynamics of social protection between 2022 and 2024 and spark your curiosity.

We wish you an interesting read.

PREAMBLE

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TABLE

1. Belgium's social protection data in 2023

This section presents the receipts and expenditures of social protection in Belgium in 2023, expressed in millions of euros, as a percentage of gross domestic product (GDP), and as a percentage of the total receipts and expenditures of social protection. In 2023, Belgium's GDP amounted to 602.4 billion euro, representing an increase of 41,067.2 million euro compared to 2022¹.

Regarding social protection expenditures, details are provided on social benefits by risk category and by type of social benefit, as well as the 'Early Estimates' for 2024.

It is important to note that for the year 2023, certain data for a number of schemes were not provided to us. No additional estimates were made for these (however, they represent only a very small portion of the total).

A) Social protection receipts

TABLE 1: AMOUNTS OF BELGIUM'S SOCIAL PROTECTION RECEIPTS IN 2023 (IN MILLION EUR)

	In million EUR	In % of GDP	In % of TSR ²
Employers' contributions	67.258,71	11,17	37,13
Protected persons' contributions	34.504,35	5,73	19,05
Government contributions	75.340,29	12,51	41,59
Other receipts	4.053,20	0,67	2,24
total receipts	181.156,55	30,07	100,00

Source: FPS Sociale Security

¹ Eurostat-data updated on 27/10/2025.

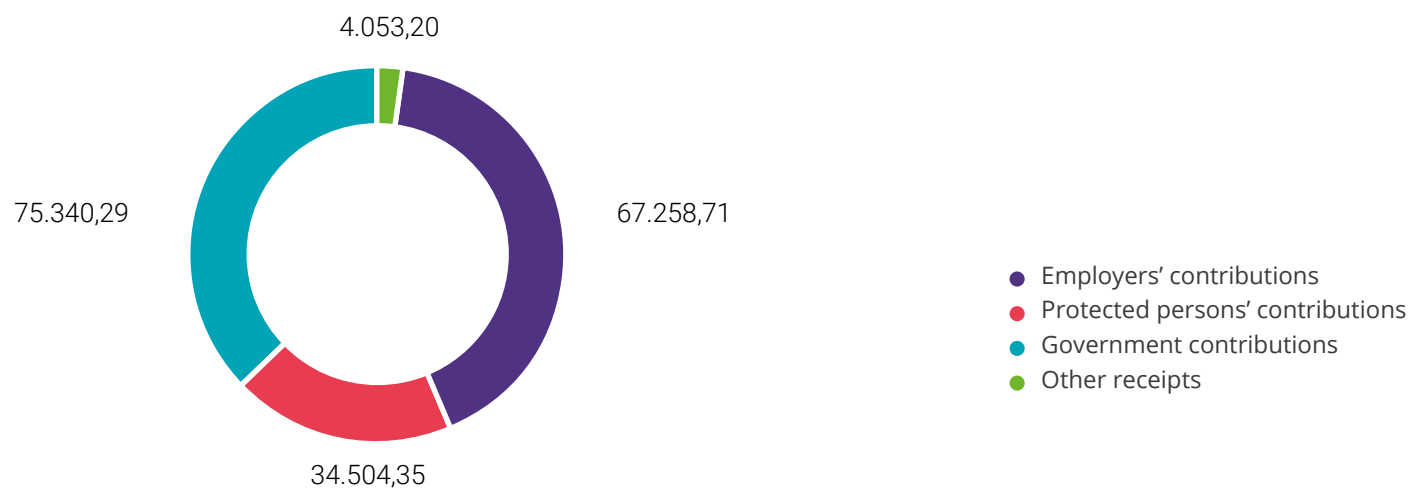
² TSR: Total Social Receipts.

Table 1 shows that in 2023, a significant part of social protection receipts comes from the government, namely 41.59% of the TSR³. This percentage is slightly higher than in 2022, when it accounted for 41.23% of total social receipts. In 2023, government expenditure remained at an elevated level, mainly due to policy measures taken to mitigate the impact of the energy crisis and ongoing inflation. As a result, government contributions to social protection have not yet returned to pre-pandemic levels.

Employers' contributions and contributions from protected persons together account for 56.18% of the financing of social protection in Belgium (37.13% from employers and 19.05% from protected persons). Other receipts accounted for 2.24% of total social receipts.

Chart 1 provides an overview of the distribution of social protection receipts in 2023 in millions of euros, as shown in table 1.

CHART 1: DISTRIBUTION OF SOCIAL RECEIPTS IN 2023 (IN MILLION EUR)



Source: FPS Sociale Security

³ Source: Eurostat.

B) Social protection expenditure

TABLE 2: BELGIUM'S SOCIAL EXPENDITURE IN 2023

	In million EUR	In % of GDP	In % of TSE ⁴
Social benefits	165.806,45	27,53	95,18
Administrative expenditure	6.165,45	1,02	3,54
Other expenditure	2.238,36	0,37	1,28
Total expenditure	174.210,26	28,92	100,00

Source: FPS Sociale Security

Table 2 shows that social benefits accounted for the largest share of social protection expenditure in 2023, namely 95.18% of total social expenditure (TSE). Administrative expenditure and other expenditure accounted for 3.54% and 1.28% of total expenditure respectively.

The ratio of the different types of expenditure to total social expenditure remained relatively stable compared to previous years.

In 2023, social protection expenditure increased both in nominal terms and as a percentage of GDP compared to the previous year. Total expenditure rose from €160.9 billion in 2022 to €174.2 billion in 2023. The share of this expenditure in relation to GDP rose from 28.55% in 2022 to 28.92% in 2023.

⁴ TSE: Total social expenditure.

C) Social benefits by risk

TABLE 3: AMOUNTS OF SOCIAL BENEFITS BY RISK IN 2023

Risks	In million EUR	In % of GDP	In % of TSB ⁵
Sickness	46.448,89	7,71	28,01
Disability	16.448,06	2,73	9,92
Old-age	69.583,94	11,55	41,97
Survivors	8.914,51	1,48	5,38
Family	12.232,62	2,03	7,38
Unemployment	5.521,04	0,92	3,33
Housing	1.262,27	0,21	0,76
Social exclusion	5.395,12	0,90	3,25
Total	165.806,45	27,53	100,00

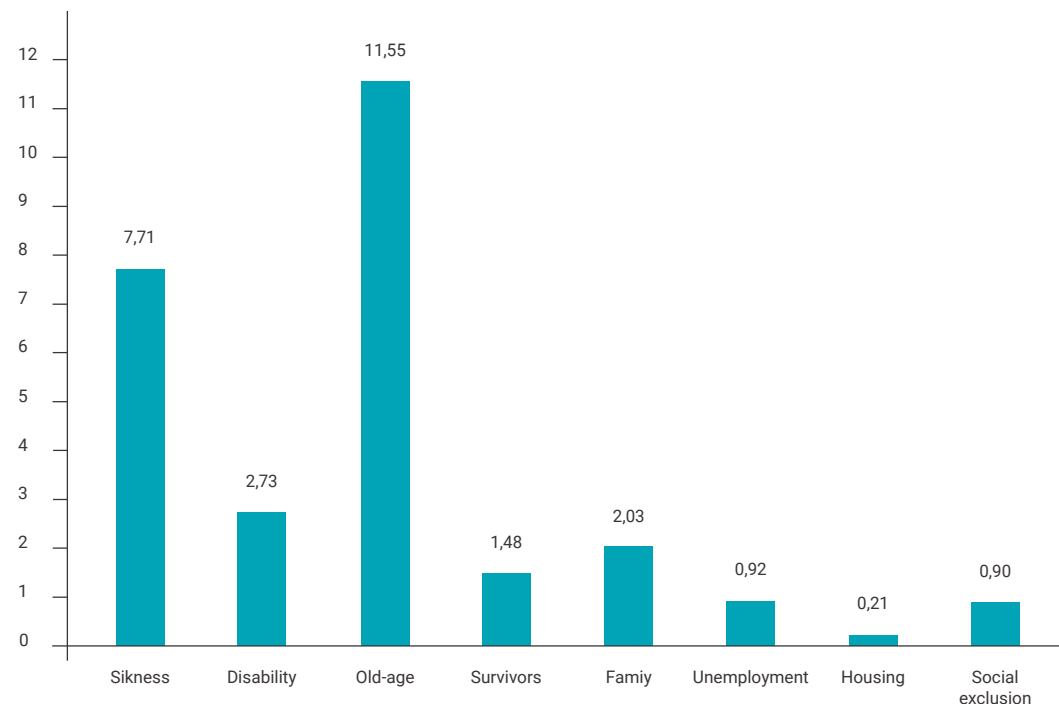
Source: FPS Sociale Security

Table 3 shows that the functions 'Old age' and 'Sickness/ Health care' are the most significant expenditure items in terms of social protection. In 2023, they represented 41.97% and 28.01% of social benefit expenditure, respectively.

In 2023, expenditure increased for nearly all functions compared to 2022, except for the functions 'Unemployment' and 'Housing'. The decline in the Unemployment function is particularly noteworthy: its share of total social benefits dropped from 3.82% to 3.33%. This decline is the result of a further decrease in temporary unemployment, which was initially introduced in response to the health crisis and maintained during the subsequent energy crisis. Additionally, employment growth contributed to a decline in overall unemployment and, by extension, to a reduction in expenditure within this function.

The ratio of other social benefits remains similar to that of previous years.

⁵ TSB: Total social benefits.

CHART 2: SOCIAL RISKS IN % OF GDP IN 2023

Source: FPS Sociale Security.

Chart 2 shows the eight social risks (functions) according to the ESSPROS methodology, expressed as percentages of GDP. The functions 'Housing' and 'Social exclusion' represent the lowest percentages in 2023, at 0.21% and 0.90% of GDP, respectively. On the other hand, the functions 'Old age' and 'Sickness/ Health care' represent the highest percentages, at 11.55% and 7.71% of GDP respectively.

D) Types of social benefits

As a reminder, the ESSPROS methodology distinguishes between two types of social benefits: cash benefits and benefits in kind.

- A **cash benefit** is a benefit that is paid in cash and does not require proof of the recipient's actual expenses. For example, sick leave with pay, old-age pension payments, ...
- A **benefit in kind** is a benefit granted in the form of goods or services (including reimbursement of expenses to protected people). Therefore, reimbursements of our "health care" insurance are regarded as benefits in kind. Among the benefits in kind, we will find for example: allowances for assistance in the daily tasks of the elderly, housing allowances, ...

TABLE 4: CASH BENEFITS AND BENEFITS IN KIND IN 2023

Risks	Cash benefits (in million EUR)	Cash benefits in % of TSB	Benefits in kind (in million EUR)	Benefits in kind in % of TSB
Sickness	5.834,88	3,52	40.614,00	24,49
Disability	12.985,54	7,83	3.462,52	2,09
Old-age	63.576,51	38,34	6.007,43	3,62
Survivors	8.888,62	5,36	25,89	0,02
Family	9.665,79	5,83	2.566,83	1,55
Unemployment	5.507,32	3,32	13,73	0,01
Housing	0,00	0,00	1.262,27	0,76
Social exclusion	2.708,43	1,63	2.686,70	1,62
Total	109.167,09	65,84	56.639,37	34,16

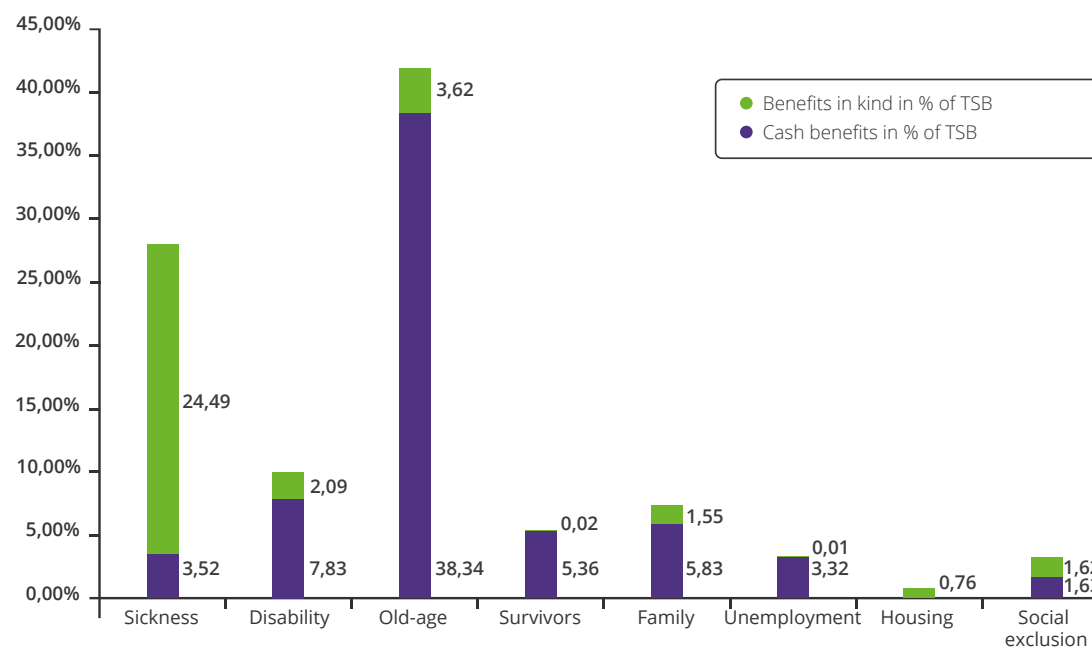
Source: FPS Sociale Security

In Belgium, social benefits are mainly provided in the form of cash benefits. In 2023, these benefits accounted for 65.84% of all social protection benefits (of which 38.34% were for the "Old age" function, 7.83% for the "Disability" function, and 19.66% for the other cash benefits). Benefits in kind accounted for 34.16% of total social benefits, of which 24.49% were for the "Sickness/Health care" function and 9.67% for the other benefits in kind.

The ratio between cash benefits and benefits in kind remained relatively stable in 2023 compared to previous years.

Chart 3 shows the share of cash benefits and benefits in kind as a percentage of total social benefits expenditure in 2023.

CHART 3: SHARE OF CASH BENEFITS AND BENEFITS IN KIND (IN % OF TSB) IN 2023



Source: FPS Sociale Security.

E) Statistical data from ESSPROS for the year 2024 'EARLY ESTIMATES

For the reference year 2024, several Member States of the European Union (EU) once again carried out an exercise known as “Early Estimates” as part of ESSPROS statistical reporting. This exercise is carried out on a voluntary basis by the Member States and involves the provision of preliminary estimates of data on social benefit expenditure for each of the eight functions, at an aggregate level. These estimates therefore do not contain the same level of detail as the mandatory reporting of the ESSPROS core system. However, they have the advantage of being available almost a year earlier than the regular data and therefore provide an initial indication of trends in social benefit expenditure, albeit with a margin of uncertainty.

TABLE 5: SOCIAL BENEFITS FROM 2018 TO 2023 (IN MILLIONS OF EUROS)

Risks	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	Early estimates 2024	Variation 2023 -2024
Sickness	35.710,57	38.159,82	41.542,32	42.911,09	46.448,89	50.457,08	8,63%
Disability	12.124,13	12.651,33	13.363,93	15.020,83	16.448,06	17.863,64	8,61%
Old-age	52.831,85	55.999,93	57.449,79	63.527,71	69.583,94	74.545,99	7,13%
Survivors	8.433,62	7.944,29	7.921,39	8.453,45	8.914,51	9.262,13	3,90%
Family	9.882,15	10.565,32	10.696,52	11.402,42	12.232,62	13.162,10	7,60%
Unemployment	7.162,34	13.048,94	9.720,08	5.845,27	5.521,04	5.734,36	3,86%
Housing	1.125,54	1.076,64	1.177,52	1.284,86	1.262,27	1.306,85	3,53%
Social exclusion	3.392,34	4.433,77	3.421,32	4.721,12	5.395,12	5.551,71	2,90%
Total	130.662,54	143.880,04	145.292,86	153.166,76	165.806,45	177.883,87	7,28%

Source: FPS Sociale Security

Table 5 shows that social benefits are estimated to increase nominally by 7.28% in 2024 compared to 2023.

The projections for 2024 indicate a significant increase in social expenditure. Benefits for 'sickness/health care', 'disability', 'family', and 'old age' are expected to increase by 8.63%, 8.61%, 7.60%, and 7.13%, respectively. This growth is partly explained by the exceeding of the pivot index in April, which automatically increased pensions, disability benefits and other social benefits by 2%. The statutory reimbursement of medical expenses also follows this automatic indexation.

In Flanders, there is an annual 2% indexation for child benefits, while other regions apply automatic indexation. Furthermore, on January 1, 2024, the minimum pension was structurally increased by 2.08%, in addition to the automatic indexation.

Besides the automatic indexation of social benefits, the ageing of the population is an important factor in the increase in expenditure, particularly for the functions "old age" and "sickness". The increasing number of retirees is driving up pension expenditure, while also increasing the need for care.

At the same time, the Belgian labor market is ageing, resulting in higher frequency and duration of absences due to disability.

This combination of demographic developments and labour market trends means that disability will reach a historic high in 2024, with the largest increase in 2024 occurring among workers in the 25 to 34 age group.

In addition to the automatic indexation of child benefit, a clear increase in social allowances will be observed in the various state entities in 2024. Due to changed income thresholds and economic conditions, more families will receive this additional support in 2024.

TABLE 6: SOCIAL BENEFITS FROM 2019 TO 2024 (IN % OF TBS)

Risks	2019	2020	2021	2022	2023	Early estimates 2024	Percentage difference 2019-2024
Sickness	27,33%	26,52%	28,59%	28,02%	28,01%	28,37%	3,79%
Disability	9,28%	8,79%	9,20%	9,81%	9,92%	10,04%	8,23%
Old-age	40,43%	38,92%	39,54%	41,48%	41,97%	41,91%	3,64%
Survivors	6,45%	5,52%	5,45%	5,52%	5,38%	5,21%	-19,33%
Family	7,56%	7,34%	7,36%	7,44%	7,38%	7,40%	-2,17%
Unemployment	5,48%	9,07%	6,69%	3,82%	3,33%	3,22%	-41,19%
Housing	0,86%	0,75%	0,81%	0,84%	0,76%	0,73%	-14,71%
Social exclusion	2,60%	3,08%	2,35%	3,08%	3,25%	3,12%	20,21%

Source: FPS Sociale Security

The overview in [Table 6](#) shows an increase in the importance of expenditure on the function 'Sickness/Health care' within total expenditure on social benefits, with 3.79% between 2019 and 2024. However, the strongest increase concerns expenditure on 'Social exclusion' and 'Disability', with increases of 20.21% and 8.23% respectively, while the importance of expenditure on the functions 'Unemployment', survivors' and 'housing' has fallen sharply, by 41.19%, 19.33% and 14.71% respectively.

2. Comparison with the other EU countries in 2022

In this chapter, we present some key figures provided by Member States to Eurostat concerning the year 2022.

For Belgium, we have used the most recent data available, while for the other countries we have used the most recent data published by Eurostat at the time of writing⁶.

It is essential to emphasize that the figures presented are gross data, i.e., without any adjustment for tax deductions or other compulsory contributions that beneficiaries are required to pay. This lack of adjustments means that some caution is required when comparing levels between Member States.

Social protection benefits can be provided to beneficiaries in numerous forms. In the context of ESSPROS, only the following categories of benefits are taken into account:

- cash payments to protected persons;
- reimbursement of expenses incurred by protected persons;
- goods and services provided directly to protected persons.

These are direct benefits, in the sense that they result in a direct increase in the disposable income of the beneficiaries.

⁶ data obtained from the Eurostat database on November 14, 2025.

A) Social protection receipts in the European Union

For the sake of readability, we do not list the data for all countries for which social protection statistics are available, but limit ourselves to a selection of them.

The complete dataset can be consulted on the Eurostat website⁷.

TABLE 7: SOCIAL PROTECTION RECEIPTS BY TYPE IN % OF GDP AND IN % OF TOTAL SOCIAL RECEIPTS (TSR) IN 2022

	Employers' contributions		Protected persons' contributions		Government contributions		Other receipts		Total	
	In % of GDP	In % of TSR	In % of GDP	In % of TSR	In % of GDP	In % of TSR	In % of GDP	In % of TSR	In % of GDP	In million EUR
EU27	10,17	35,02	6,14	21,15	11,90	40,98	0,83	2,86	29,04	4.695.132,10
BE	11,15	37,84	5,56	18,86	12,15	41,23	0,61	2,06	29,46	165.336,51
DK	3,85	11,70	2,59	7,85	24,54	74,48	1,97	5,98	32,95	125.390,17
DE	10,73	34,09	9,56	30,38	10,69	33,99	0,48	1,54	31,46	1.255.189,40
IE	3,27	25,15	1,60	12,32	7,50	57,60	0,64	4,93	13,02	67.795,39
ES	10,95	42,83	2,97	11,63	11,56	45,22	0,08	0,32	25,56	351.739,32
FR	13,54	38,75	5,57	15,93	15,23	43,59	0,60	1,73	34,93	927.099,90
IT	10,46	34,55	4,46	14,74	14,84	49,00	0,52	1,71	30,28	605.113,00
LU	6,30	26,61	5,82	24,58	10,82	45,68	0,74	3,13	23,68	18.173,59
NL	10,16	32,19	8,83	27,99	8,31	26,34	4,25	13,48	31,56	313.653,00
FI	9,54	30,85	4,57	14,76	15,18	49,05	1,65	5,35	30,94	82.349,28
SE	11,41	38,07	2,72	9,08	15,15	50,53	0,70	2,32	29,98	164.029,22

Source: Eurostat / FPS Social Security

In **2022**, social contributions from employers and protected persons, were still the main source of funding for social protection in the EU. Together, these contributions accounted for 56.17% of total social protection receipts in EU27. For Belgium, the share of employer contributions

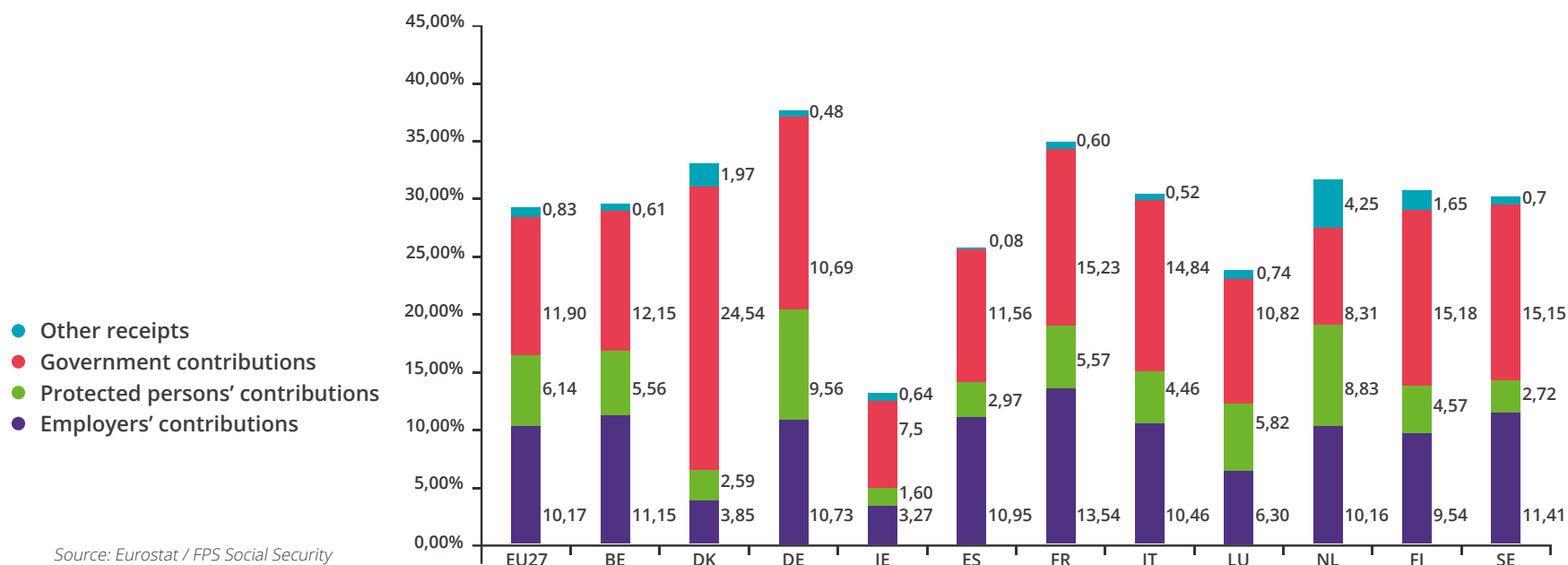
⁷ <https://ec.europa.eu/eurostat/web/main/data/database>

was significantly above the EU average, at 37.84% of total social receipts, compared to 35.02% for the EU27. Contributions from protected persons in Belgium amounted to 18.86%, which is lower than the EU27 average of 21.15%.

Regarding government contributions, Belgium recorded a share of 41.23% of total social receipts in 2022, slightly above the EU27 average of 40.98%. This remains substantial but is lower than in 2021, when the share stood at 43.66%. Despite this decline, the level is still higher than before the health crisis, partly due to additional measures related to the energy crisis. The decrease reflects a broader European trend caused by the phasing out of temporary COVID-19 measures.

Furthermore, it is evident that the organization of social protection in different countries influences the income structure in those countries. For example, government contributions will be higher in countries with universal systems than in countries with insurance-based systems.

CHART 4: DISTRIBUTION OF SOCIAL PROTECTION RECEIPTS IN % OF GDP IN 2022 IN THE EU

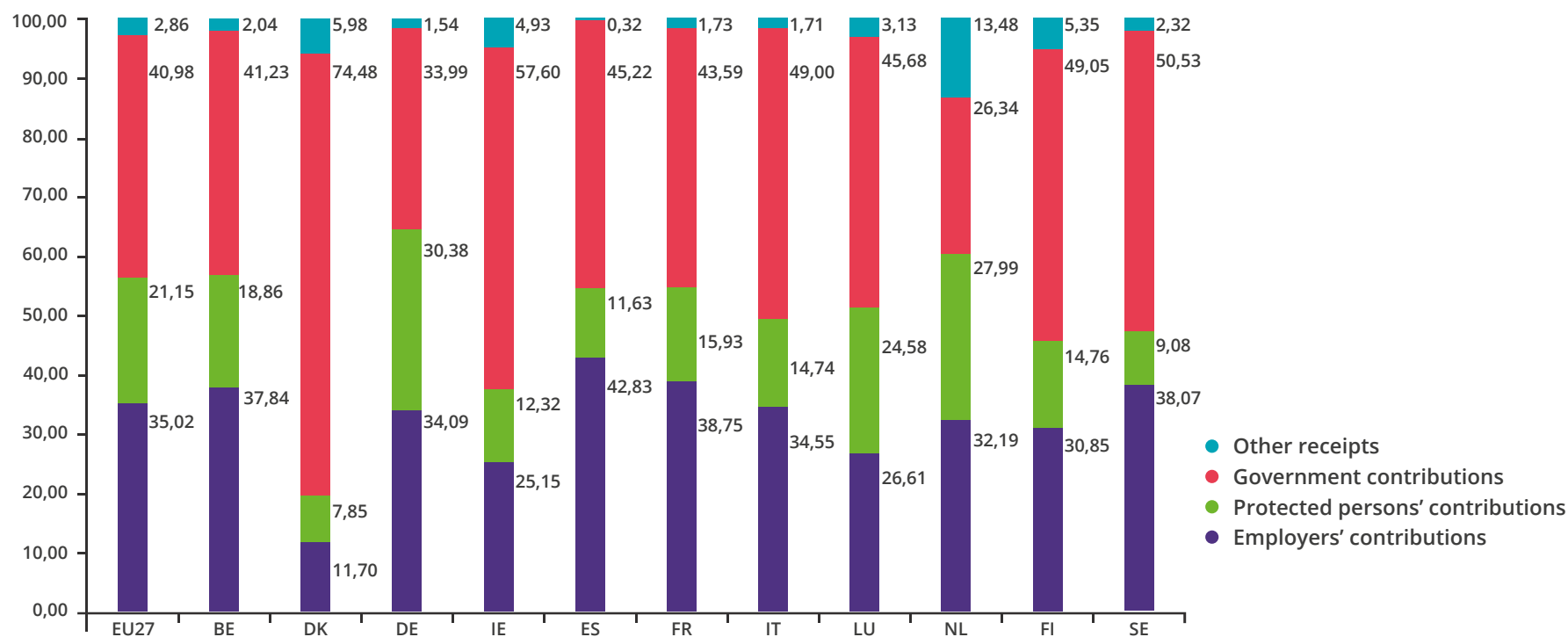


Source: Eurostat / FPS Social Security

Chart 4 offers a twofold comparative perspective on social protection receipts in the European Union. On one hand, it highlights the relative distribution of social protection funding sources in each country; on the other hand, it shows the relative size of the financial burden of social protection on the economy of each studied country.

In 2022, the EU27 average was 29.04% of GDP, a level achieved by most selected countries. Exceptions are Spain, Luxembourg, and especially Ireland, which at 13.02% remains well below the average. France, Denmark, and the Netherlands are among the countries with the highest relative expenditures, at 34.93%, 32.95%, and 31.56% of GDP, respectively. However, it is important to note that, although some countries show a similar financial scale for social protection, this does not necessarily reflect a similar financing profile, as will be illustrated in the following chart.

CHART 5 : DISTRIBUTION OF SOCIAL PROTECTION RECEIPTS IN % OF TSR IN 2022 IN THE EU



Source: Eurostat / FPS Social Security

Chart 5 shows that government and employers' contributions account for the largest share of social protection receipts. This chart also highlights trends in the financing of social security systems, which may be influenced by characteristics of the Bismarckian and Beveridgean models. Northern countries such as Denmark, Sweden, and Finland follow the universal model, in which government contributions play a prominent role in the financing of social protection systems. In contrast, countries such as Belgium illustrate a predominantly insurance-based model, which relies mainly on social contributions. However, the distinction remains theoretical, as all systems contain hybrid mechanisms.

B) Social protection expenditure in the European Union

Table 8 shows the distribution of social protection expenditure in millions of euros and as a percentage of GDP. This allows us to see what proportion of national wealth is redistributed through social protection.

The share of social benefits accounts for approximately 95% or more of total social expenditures in most EU countries.

TABLE 8: STRUCTURE OF SOCIAL PROTECTION EXPENDITURE IN 2022

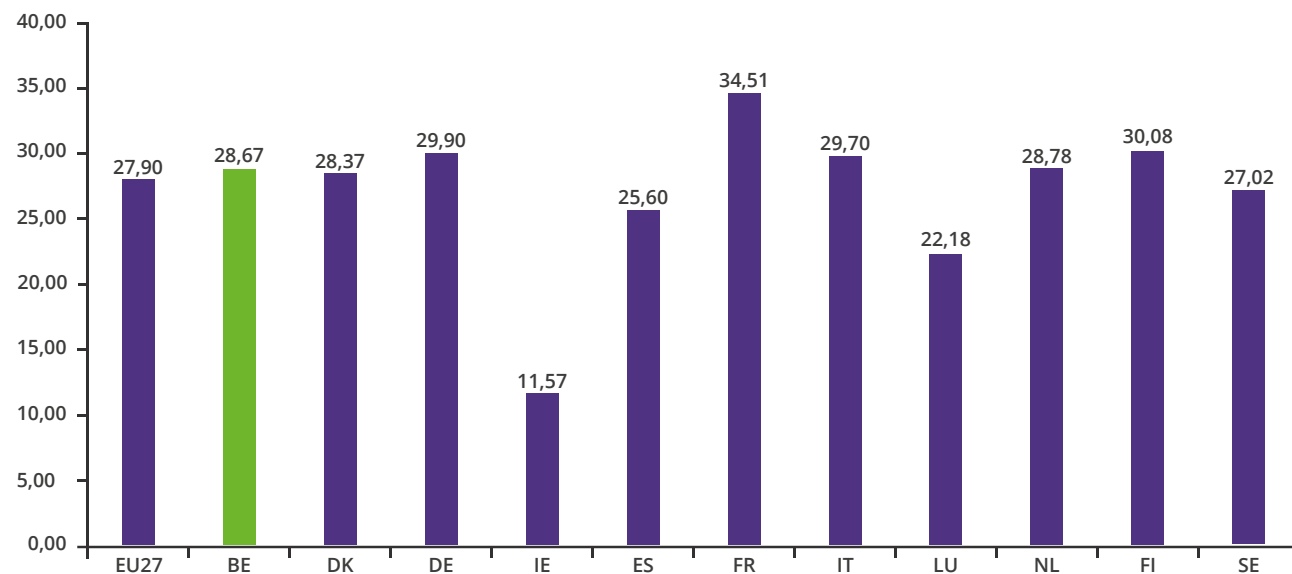
	Social benefits		Administrative expenditure		Other expenditure		Social expenditure	
	In million EUR	In % of GDP	In million EUR	In % of GDP	In million EUR	In % of GDP	In million EUR	In % of GDP
EU27	4.325.519,77	26,75	139.714,07	0,86	46.747,35	0,29	4.511.981,19	27,90
BE	153.166,76	27,29	5.797,43	1,03	1.940,85	0,35	160.905,04	28,67
DK	103.445,91	27,18	4.534,43	1,19	:	:	107.980,34	28,37
DE	1.143.591,62	28,67	43.422,08	1,09	5.625,66	0,14	1.192.639,36	29,90
IE	58.113,99	11,16	2.138,05	0,41	:	:	60.252,04	11,57
ES	346.594,78	25,19	5.590,58	0,41	36,26	0,00	352.221,61	25,60
FR	854.228,61	32,19	35.871,89	1,35	25.736,67	0,97	915.837,16	34,51
IT	575.734,00	28,81	12.050,00	0,60	5.620,00	0,28	593.404,00	29,70
LU	16.764,09	21,85	200,96	0,26	52,09	0,07	17.017,13	22,18
NL	246.535,00	24,81	15.445,00	1,55	4.167,00	0,42	266.147,00	26,78
FI	78.772,14	29,60	1.275,41	0,48	0,00	0,00	80.047,55	30,08
SE	148.965,06	27,22	2.742,72	0,50	:	:	151.707,78	27,72

Source: Eurostat / FPS Social Security

In 2022, social benefits expenditures as a percentage of GDP continued to decline in Europe, dropping from an average of 28.46% of GDP in 2021 to 26.75% in 2022.

Chart 6 shows social protection expenditure as a percentage of GDP in 2022 in the EU.

CHART 6: SOCIAL EXPENDITURE IN % OF GDP IN 2022



Source: Eurostat / FPS Social Security

C) Social benefits by risk in the European Union

To facilitate comparison between the different countries, the data are expressed as a percentage of GDP. This approach allows for a proportional comparison of social expenditures relative to national wealth.

TABLE 9: SOCIAL BENEFITS IN % OF GDP IN 2022

In % of GDP	Sickness / Healt Care	Disability	Old-age	Survivors	Family / Children	Unemployment	Housing	Social exclusion
EU27	8,03	1,87	10,94	1,48	2,30	1,07	0,34	0,71
BE	7,64	2,68	11,32	1,51	2,03	1,04	0,23	0,84
DK	6,37	4,68	10,40	0,21	2,92	0,83	0,55	1,21
DE	9,56	2,05	10,43	1,59	3,39	0,94	0,51	0,20
IE	4,93	0,60	3,19	0,29	1,03	0,48	0,58	0,07
ES	7,42	1,60	10,20	2,29	1,46	1,65	0,12	0,46
FR	9,80	2,07	12,82	1,57	2,24	1,80	0,59	1,32
IT	6,59	1,55	14,17	2,34	1,50	1,20	0,04	1,42
LU	6,14	2,44	7,31	1,41	3,23	0,64	0,08	0,60
NL	9,26	2,19	9,26	0,75	1,19	0,47	0,40	1,29
FI	7,00	2,65	12,82	0,73	3,02	1,54	0,95	0,88
SE	7,77	2,52	12,37	0,19	2,78	0,72	0,37	0,51

Source: Eurostat / FPS Social Security

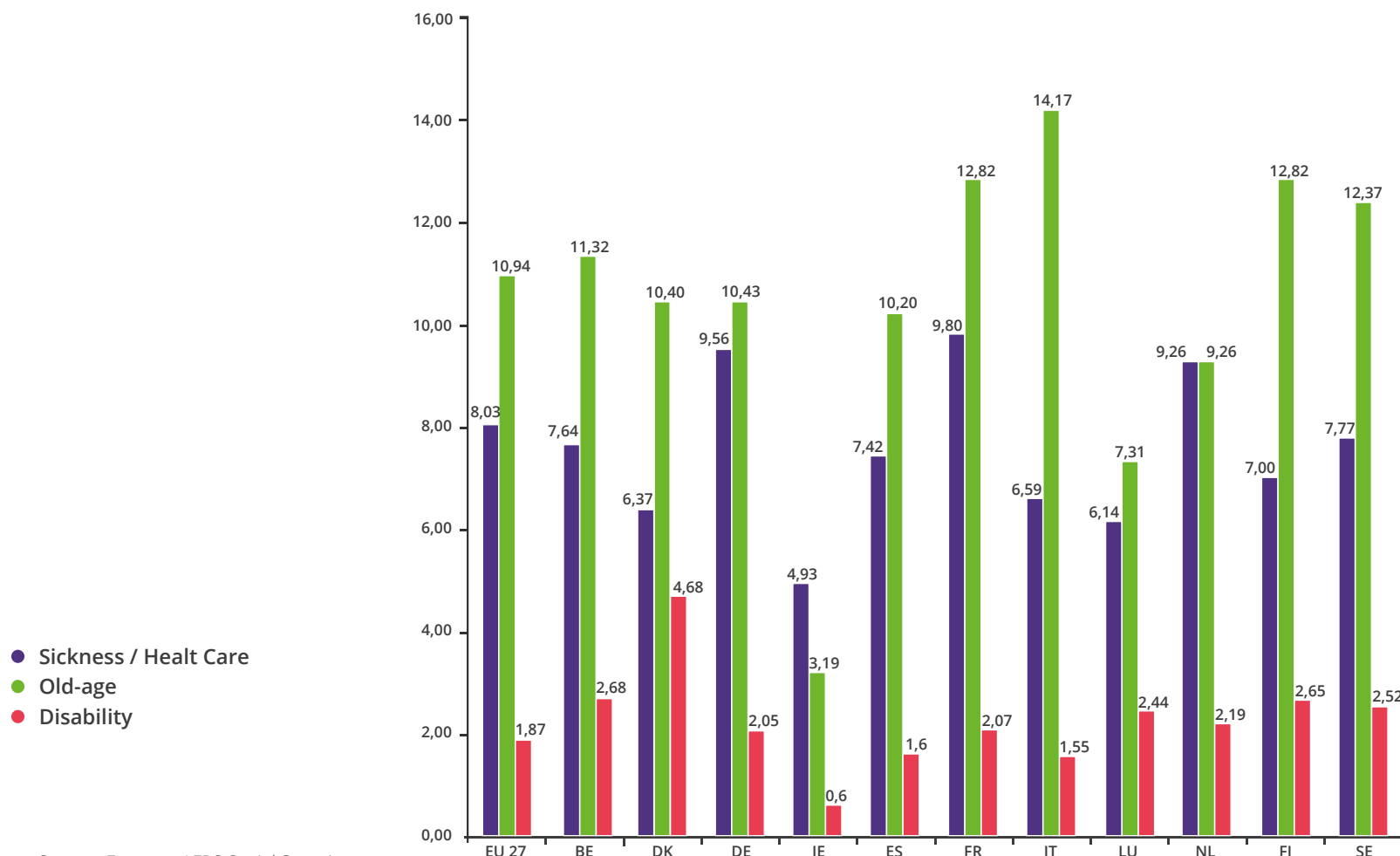
Table 9 presents the share of each function in the various Member States of the European Union. In 2022, Belgium was above the EU27 average. The exceptions were the functions “Sickness/Health care”, “Family/Children”, “Unemployment” and “Housing”.

Expenditure on the “Unemployment” function continued to decline in all Member States in 2022. The European average decreased from 1.69% to 1.07% of GDP between 2021 and 2022. Belgium remained below this average, with unemployment expenditure amounting to 1.04% of GDP in 2022. It is noteworthy, however, that despite the overall decline, France (1.80%), Spain (1.65%), and Finland (1.54%) still recorded significantly higher levels than the EU average.

With regard to the “Old age” function, expenditures remained particularly high in Italy, France, Finland, and Sweden in 2022. In Belgium, these expenditures amounted to 11.32% of GDP, exceeding the EU average of 10.94%.

Chart 7 shows the distribution of social benefits for the functions 'Sickness/Health care', Old age' and 'Disability' as a percentage of GDP in 2022 in the EU.

CHART 7: DISTRIBUTION OF SOCIAL BENEFITS FOR THE SICKNESS /HEALTH CARE, OLD-AGE AND DISABILITY FUNCTIONS IN % OF GDP IN 2022



Source: Eurostat / FPS Social Security

TABLE 10: SOCIAL BENEFITS IN % OF TOTAL SOCIAL BENEFITS IN 2022

In % of TSB	Sickness / Health Care	Disability	Old-age	Survivors	Family / Children	Unemployment	Housing	Social exclusion
EU27	30,01	7,01	40,9	5,54	8,58	4,01	1,28	2,66
BE	28,02	9,81	41,48	5,52	7,44	3,82	0,84	3,08
DK	23,44	17,22	38,28	0,79	10,76	3,05	2,03	4,44
DE	33,34	7,14	36,39	5,56	11,83	3,27	1,78	0,68
IE	44,13	5,37	28,63	2,56	9,21	4,33	5,15	0,62
ES	29,44	6,34	40,47	9,10	5,79	6,55	0,48	1,82
FR	30,46	6,42	39,82	4,86	6,95	5,59	1,82	4,09
IT	22,88	5,39	49,18	8,11	5,21	4,18	0,12	4,93
LU	28,09	11,18	33,46	6,48	14,76	2,92	0,38	2,73
NL	37,34	8,81	37,35	3,01	4,81	1,88	1,60	5,20
FI	23,65	8,95	43,33	2,46	10,22	5,21	3,23	2,97
SE	28,55	9,25	45,44	0,70	10,20	2,64	1,36	1,86

Source: Eurostat / FPS Social Security

Table 10 shows the share that each function represents in the total benefits. Benefits related to the “Old age” function account for the largest share of social benefits, followed by benefits related to the “Sickness and health care” function.

It is noteworthy that the European average (EU27) for the function “Unemployment” as a percentage of total social expenditure decreased from 5.95% in 2021 to 4.01% in 2022. This decline can be attributed to the discontinuation of various covid-related support measures and to the growth in employment in 2022, both within and outside Belgium.

At the same time, the share of expenditure on “Old-age” increased from 39.78% to 40.90%, which may indicate a gradual ageing of the population and an increase in pension-related expenditure.

CHART 8: DISTRIBUTION OF SOCIAL BENEFITS FOR THE SICKNESS/HEALTH CARE AND OLD-AGE FUNCTIONS IN % OF TOTAL SOCIAL BENEFITS IN 2022

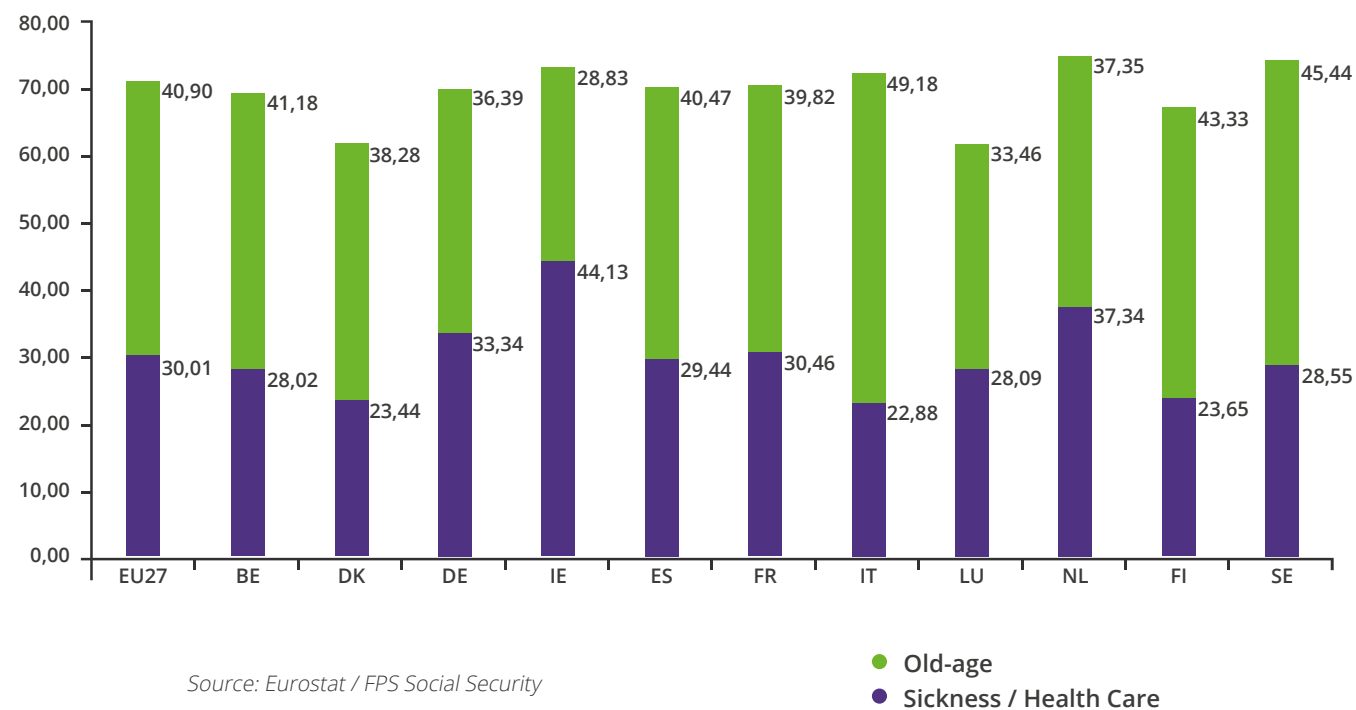


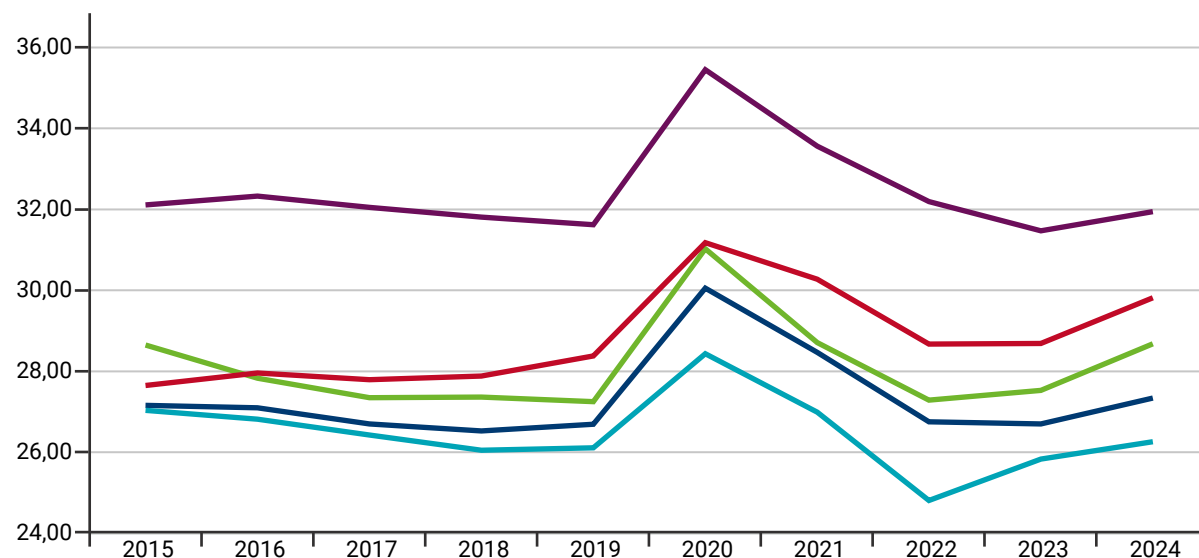
Chart 8 shows that benefits for 'Old age' and 'Sickness/ Health care' account for more than half of total benefits. The European average (for the EU27) amounts to 70.91% of the total benefits. In some countries, such as the Netherlands and Sweden, these benefits will continue to account for more than 73% of total benefits in 2022, while Belgium, with 69.50%, remained below the European average.

D) Early estimates – social benefits in the aftermath of the Covid and energy crises

Early estimates Early estimates are also available for other EU Member States⁸. They allow us to paint a picture of social protection in Europe throughout the Covid and energy crises.

The chart below and the accompanying explanation are taken from the publication 'Figure in Focus'⁹.

CHART 9: EXPENDITURE ON SOCIAL BENEFITS, IN % OF THE GDP (2015 - 2024)



● EU27	27,16	27,10	26,70	26,53	26,69	30,06	28,47	26,75	26,70	27,34
● BE	28,65	27,83	27,35	27,36	27,25	31,03	28,71	27,29	27,53	28,68
● DE	27,65	27,96	27,79	27,88	28,38	31,18	30,28	28,67	28,69	29,82
● FR	32,11	32,33	32,05	31,81	31,62	35,45	33,56	32,19	31,47	31,94
● NL	27,04	26,82	26,43	26,05	26,11	28,44	26,99	24,81	25,83	26,26

Source: Eurostat / FPS Social Security

⁸ The "Early Estimates" are organised on the basis of a 'gentlemen's agreement' between Eurostat and the Member States. They are therefore not part of the mandatory work under ESSPROS, which explains why they are not available for all countries.

⁹ Dépenses de protection sociale : augmentation des dépenses en 2023 et 2024, après une baisse durant les années post-COVID-19 | Service Public Fédéral - Sécurité Sociale

In 2020, all countries shown in [Chart 9](#), experienced a similar increase in social benefit expenditure as a percentage of GDP, as a direct result of the health crisis. From 2021 and 2022 onwards, this trend will reverse, and all countries will gradually return to their pre-pandemic levels. This confirms that the COVID-19 shock was a one-off event rather than a structural one. However, the speed of this recovery varies from country to country.

Although expenditure as a percentage of GDP will have fallen in 2022 for Belgium, its neighbouring countries and the average of the 27 EU Member States, the data for 2023 show divergent developments. Social expenditure will increase in Belgium and the Netherlands, while it will decrease in France and remain relatively stable for Germany and the EU-27 average.

Early estimates for 2024 suggest that this increase in expenditure as a percentage of GDP will continue for Belgium and the Netherlands, and that Germany, France and the EU-27 average will also see an increase. For Germany, this will be a fairly significant increase. For France and the EU-27 average, the increase will be rather slight. The early estimates indicate that Belgian expenditure will continue to deviate from the EU-27 average and that this expenditure will show the strongest increase, closely followed by that of Germany. However, as these are preliminary estimates for 2024, these results should be interpreted with caution.

Abbreviations

GDP:	Gross Domestic Product
ESSPROS:	European System of integrated Social PROtection Statistics
EUROSTAT:	Statistical Office of the European Union
FPS:	Federal Public Service
TSE:	Total Social Expenditure
TPB:	Total Social Benefits
TSR:	Total Social Receipts
EU:	European Union
EU27:	The 27 countries of the European Union (Austria, Belgium, Bulgaria, Cyprus, Czech Republic, Croatia, Germany, Denmark, Greece, Spain, Estonia, Finland, France, Hungary, Ireland, Italy, Latvia, Lithuania, Luxembourg, Malta, Poland, Portugal, The Netherlands, Romania, Sweden, Slovak Republic, Slovenia)

AT	Austria	IE	Ireland
BE	Belgium	IT	Italy
BG	Bulgaria	LV	Latvia
CY	Cyprus	LT	Lithuania
CZ	Czech Republic	LU	Luxembourg
HR	Croatia	MT	Malta
DE	Germany	PL	Poland
DK	Denmark	PT	Portugal
EL	Greece	NL	The Netherlands
ES	Spain	RO	Romania
EE	Estonia	SE	Sweden
FI	Finland	SK	Slovak Republic
FR	France	SI	Slovenia
HU	Hungary	UK	United Kingdom

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